

Applied Accessibility

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Assignment 11.2

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Comparison and Contrast: Example 1 vs. Example 2

Example 1: Traditional Form Layout

- **Label Clarity:** Uses visible labels next to each field ("First Name:", "*Email Address:"). This is beneficial for screen readers and improves clarity for users.
- **Asterisk Usage:** Clearly marks required fields with an asterisk and explains what it means ("* required field"), which helps both visual users and screen readers.
- **Button Styling:** The "Submit" button is prominent with a visual bevel.
- **Layout & Spacing:** Form fields are tightly packed, which might be harder to navigate on smaller devices.
- **Visual Cues:** Relies on visual emphasis (red triangle before link), which may not translate well to assistive technologies.
- **Accessibility Flaws:**
 - No fieldset or form grouping.
 - "Click here" link text lacks meaningful context for screen readers.

Example 2: Modern Minimalist Layout

- **Simplified Input:** Only asks for an email, making it easier and faster for users.
- **Supporting Text:** Uses bullet points to explain the newsletter's purpose and benefits, which improves user understanding.
- **Checkbox Option:** Includes an "Opt-out" checkbox, supporting user control. However, it could benefit from a more descriptive label or explanation.
- **Visual Cues:** Good use of white space and bullet points for readability.
- **Accessibility Strengths:**
 - Cleaner layout aids screen magnifier users.
 - Bullet points break up text well.
- **Accessibility Flaws:**
 - No visible label for the email input (could fail screen readers).
 - "Submit" button is disabled until input is detected, but there's no feedback on why it's disabled.
 - The checkbox might not be keyboard accessible if improperly coded.

Using what you discovered from the research and incorporating observations from the images, identify five or more ways that usability could be improved in Example 1. Provide links to your five sites.

1. Add Explicit Labels with “for” Attributes

Example 1 has visible labels but lacks proper association with input fields for screen readers.

Improvement: Use `<label for="email">Email Address</label>` linked to the corresponding input's id.

Why: Screen readers rely on these associations to announce form fields properly.

Reference Site: WebAIM Newsletter Form <https://webaim.org/newsletter/>

2. Provide Error Feedback and Validation

Example 1 has no feedback if the form is submitted with missing or invalid input.

Improvement: Add inline error messages like: `<span class="error" id="emailError">Please enter a valid email address.</span>`

Why: Helps users correct issues immediately, especially those using screen readers or cognitive aids. Mailchimp gives real-time error validation and alerts in an accessible way.

Reference Site: Mailchimp <https://mailchimp.com/>

3. Improve Keyboard Navigation and Focus States

Example 1 has no visual cue when fields or buttons are focused.

Improvement: Add clear focus indicators that clearly show when a button, text, etc., is being selected.

Why: Essential for keyboard-only users and helps everyone track navigation. Smashing Magazine implements clear visual focus styles and full keyboard accessibility.

Reference Site: Smashing Magazine <https://www.smashingmagazine.com/>

4. Replace “Click Here” Link with Descriptive Text

The “Click here to close this window” link in Example 1 uses vague language.

Improvement: Change it to something more descriptive like:

```
<a href="#" aria-label="Close sign-up form window">Close this form</a>
```

Why: Descriptive links improve navigation for users with screen readers or cognitive challenges. A List Apart uses clearly worded links and avoids ambiguous terms like “click here.”

Reference Site: A List Apart <https://alistapart.com/articles/>

5. Optimize Layout and Mobile Responsiveness

Example 1 has fields that are cramped with little spacing, and the form likely isn’t mobile-friendly.

Improvement: Use responsive CSS, such as media queries, flexible widths, and padding, and stack fields vertically.

Why: Improves readability and usability on all screen sizes. Nielsen Norman Group’s forms adapt well to small screens and use generous spacing.

Reference Site: Nielsen Norman Group <https://www.nngroup.com/>

The Pets-R-Us company would like users to be able to sign up for a newsletter, and is asking you to provide a mock-up of a revised version of Example 1 that incorporates your recommendations. Use a tool of your choice to create this visualization.

Subscribe to our newsletter

First Name

Last Name

Email Address *

⚠ Please enter a valid email address

Zip Code

Subscribe

Fields marked with * are required

[Close this form](#)